

middle-order provides the 2021 champion with seven bowling options too, ensuring neither department is comprised.

With Cameron Green and spin all-rounder Ashton Agar also on the roster, Australia has enough wiggle room to extend its batting depth and allow the top-order to go hell for leather. The Aussies are the fastest-scoring team in T20Is in the last 12 months, averaging 10.11 per six balls, and with a top-three comprising David Warner, Travis Head and Marsh, they would back themselves to continue in a similar vein.

With Tim David and wicketkeeper Matthew Wade entrusted with the role of going berserk at the death, there is little that will deter Australia from its approach.

To back up its batting might, Australia will unleash the enviable pace troika of Pat Cummins, Mitchell Starc and Josh Hazlewood, with Adam Zampa helming the spin attack. While Cummins has overseen Sunrisers Hyderabad's fearless approach in the IPL and has also had a fruitful outing with the ball, Starc's dwindling returns in the shortest format could pose a concern.

As cover, Australia has the option of roping in Nathan Ellis, a proven death-overs specialist who can also thrive across phases with his variations.

Though it's a long shot, the team that comes close to potentially upsetting powerhouses England and Australia is Namibia, which qualified for its third consecutive T20 World Cup after an unbeaten run of six games in the Africa Region Qualifier tournament last year.

Currently ranked No. 14 in the world, Namibia stunned Sri Lanka in the opening game of the 2022 T20 World Cup and had shown an appetite for a fight in the tournament in the preceding year.

The African nation will be led by all-rounder Gerhard Erasmus, who bats in the top order and can also open the bowling with his off-break. He will helm a 15-member squad that includes 12 players who featured in Namibia's victorious Africa Qualifier



campaign.

One spot above Namibia in the global team rankings, Scotland too has punched above its weight in the past, having beaten West Indies in the last edition of the tournament.

The Scottish Saltires also emerged from the Europe Region Qualifier unscathed, winning six out of six games while also beating a higher-ranked Irish side.

Leading from the front is top-order batter Richie Berrington, who was Scotland's joint-highest run-scorer in the Qualifier event, with

Race against time: Aussie T20I skipper Mitchell Marsh has not played since his last appearance for Delhi Capitals in the IPL on April 3 due to a right hamstring strain. GETTY IMAGES

248 runs at an impressive strike rate over 170.

The tournament was headlined by the Scottish pair of Ollie Hairs, who struck at over 200 for 248 runs, and left-arm seamer Bradley Currie, who was the top wicket-taker, with 12 scalps at 4.80 runs an over.

The lowest-ranked side in the group, Oman (18), was also unbeaten in the Asia Qualifier tournament last year and clinched the final against Nepal in a thrilling Super Over finish after thrashing Bahrain by 10 wickets in the semifinal, which confirmed its participation in the upcoming World Cup.

The team will have a new skipper in 31-year-old all-rounder Aqib Ilyas, who takes over from 36-year-old Zeeshan Maqsood, who will make his third appearance for Oman at the T20 World Cup after 2016 and 2021.

The bowling will be spearheaded by left-arm seamer and Peshawar-born Bilal Khan, known for his scorching yorkers.

Two teams that will qualify

It will probably come down to the June 8 clash between England and Australia in Bridgetown as far as deciding the top team in the group is concerned.

Dark horse

Scotland is most well-equipped to stage an upset, having previously beaten Test-playing nations at the T20 World Cup. England, which has lost to Netherlands and Ireland in previous editions of the World Cup, will be most wary. England has already been stung by Scotland in the past, having lost an ODI by six runs back in 2018.

« Australia's pantheon of all-rounders
lend dynamism to the middle-order »